FIXING BROKEN CITIES

From national policy advocacy to ground-up capacity-building, Janaagraha shows how patient institutional reform can reshape Indian cities at scale

By **AJAY SUKUMARAN**

JANAAGRAHA, *Bengaluru*

Key people: **Swati and Ramesh Ramanathan,** Founders; **Srikanth Viswanathan**, CEO

Year of inception: **2001**



HEMANT MISHRA

When Janaagraha was founded in 2001, its faith was almost romantic: that the organised voice of citizens could be the lever that fixed India's broken cities. Swati and Ramesh Ramanathan, who walked away from successful careers in the US to return to India, believed participatory democracy would be the silver bullet for urban dysfunction. But reality intervened quickly.

"We came in with a very problem-solving approach," says Swati. "What is wrong in our cities? Why isn't government solving it? And therefore, what can we do?" That framing led to a crucial realisation: "You can't avoid working with government if you have ambitions of transformation at scale. Government is the vehicle through which scale happens."

At the same time, the founders insist that this engagement never meant co-option. Over

BENEFICIARYSPEAK

"Ward Samiti Balaga, a coalition formed through Janaagraha's efforts, connects active citizens across wards and enables direct engagement with civic officials—not just to raise grievances, but to offer solutions"

VIDYA GOGGI, *Core team member, Ward Samiti Balaga, Bengaluru*